

D922

Middle Grades Methods

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

During a lesson on ecosystems, a seventh-grade teacher whose room has a class aquarium has students hold up mini whiteboards, then slows down when half the answers are wrong. The school has 900 students. What type of assessment is this?

- A. Not an assessment, because nothing is graded.
- B. Summative assessment.
- C. Formative assessment.
- D. Standardized assessment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which of these is a summative assessment?

- A. An exit ticket used to plan tomorrow's lesson.
- B. An end-of-unit test recorded as a grade.
- C. A pre-test given before the unit starts.
- D. Peer feedback on a first draft.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A new sixth-grade teacher who moved from a high school is starting the first week of school. Her classroom has a reading corner with beanbags. Which approach best prevents behavior problems?

- A. Wait to see what problems come up, then set consequences.
- B. Teach, model, and practice routines for entering, transitions, and getting help, and praise students who follow them.
- C. Post the rules and assume students will follow them.
- D. Require strict silence at all times, since young adolescents always need tight control.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

In a four-person group project on local history, one student does all the work while others chat. The school library just added 300 new books. The project earns a single group grade. What change best fixes this?

- A. Give each member a distinct, necessary role and assess each member individually as well as the group.
- B. Stop using group work, since young adolescents cannot collaborate.
- C. Keep the single group grade and remind students to share the work.
- D. Let students choose groups of friends.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In a jigsaw activity, each group member gets a unique piece of information that the group needs to finish the task. Which element of cooperative learning does this build most directly?

- A. Individual accountability.
- B. Competition between students.
- C. Grouping by ability.
- D. Positive interdependence.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A teacher whose class includes students from many cultural and language backgrounds is planning a persuasive-writing unit. The unit will end before spring break. Which plan is most culturally responsive?

- A. Add one heritage celebration day at the end.
- B. Simplify the writing task for some groups of students.
- C. Have students argue about issues in their own communities, use mentor texts by diverse authors, and hold everyone to the same high standard.
- D. Treat every student exactly the same and avoid cultural topics.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A sixth-grade teacher who uses a paper planner writes the objective “Students will compare fractions using benchmarks like 1/2.” Her planned quiz asks students to define “numerator” and “denominator.” The quiz has eight questions. What is the problem?

- A. The quiz does not measure the objective; it should require comparing fractions with benchmarks.
- B. The lesson needs more activities.
- C. The objective should be rewritten to match the quiz.
- D. There is no problem, since both are about fractions.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

Seventh graders in a room with a broken thermostat grow restless and off task during a 50-minute lecture. The teacher coaches track after school. What is the best adjustment?

- A. Ignore it, since off-task behavior is always a deliberate choice.
- B. Give detentions for being off task.
- C. Lengthen the lectures to build stamina.
- D. Break the lesson into short segments with movement, partner talk, and some student choice.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

Students who once wrote paragraphs on paper now type the same paragraphs in a word processor, with no other change. The school bought 150 new laptops this year. Which SAMR level is this?

- A. Substitution.
- B. Redefinition.
- C. Modification.
- D. Augmentation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Students co-author a multimedia report with a class in another country and get live feedback from outside experts, which could not happen without the technology. Which SAMR level is this?

- A.** Augmentation.
- B.** Modification.
- C.** Substitution.
- D.** Redefinition.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

During a heated class debate on the day of the school play, a student notices anger building and takes three slow breaths before responding calmly. The debate topic was school uniforms. Which SEL competency is the student showing most clearly?

- A.** Self-awareness.
- B.** Social awareness.
- C.** Self-management.
- D.** Relationship skills.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A lesson asks students to retell a conflict from the other person’s point of view and name how that person may have felt. Which SEL competency does it build?

- A.** Self-awareness.
- B.** Social awareness.
- C.** Responsible decision-making.
- D.** Self-management.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

During a lesson on ecosystems, a seventh-grade teacher ~~whose room has a class aquarium~~ has students hold up mini whiteboards, then slows down when half the answers are wrong. ~~The school has 900 students.~~ What type of assessment is this?

Target word: assessment purpose **Decides:** Evidence gathered during learning changes instruction on the spot.

A	Confusion set	Assessment is about gathering evidence, not about grades.
B	Inverted operation	Summative measures learning at the end, not during it.
C	Correct	The results shape instruction in the moment.
D	Adjacent category	Standardized tests are given under uniform external conditions.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

Which of these is a summative assessment?

Target word: identify summative **Decides:** End of learning, used to report achievement.

A	Inverted operation	Used to adjust instruction, so formative.
B	Correct	Measures learning at the end for reporting.
C	Adjacent category	Diagnostic, used before instruction.
D	Confusion set	Feedback during learning is formative.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A new sixth-grade teacher ~~who moved from a high school~~ is starting the first week of school. ~~Her classroom has a reading corner with beanbags.~~ Which approach best prevents behavior problems?

Target word: proactive management **Decides:** Routines must be taught and practiced, not just announced.

A	Inverted operation	Reactive rather than proactive.
B	Correct	Explicit teaching of routines prevents most problems.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out teaching and practice.
D	Absolute language	Structure matters, but young adolescents also need interaction.

4. Answer A Concept 3

In a four-person group project on local history, one student does all the work while others chat. ~~The school library just added 300 new books.~~ The project earns a single group grade. What change best fixes this?

Target word: cooperative learning fix **Decides:** Needed roles plus individual accountability.

A	Correct	Creates both positive interdependence and individual accountability.
B	Absolute language	Structured cooperation works well at this age.
C	Dropped element	Still no individual accountability.
D	Adjacent category	Changes who is in the group, not how it works.

5. Answer D Concept 3 · transfer

In a jigsaw activity, each group member gets a unique piece of information that the group needs to finish the task. Which element of cooperative learning does this build most directly?

Target word: name the element **Decides:** The group cannot succeed without every member.

A	Confusion set	Accountability is about assessing each member; the jigsaw design makes members needed.
B	Inverted operation	The structure makes students depend on each other, not compete.
C	Adjacent category	A grouping choice, not an element of cooperation.
D	Correct	Each member's piece is necessary for the group.

6. Answer C Concept 4

A teacher whose class includes students from many cultural and language backgrounds is planning a persuasive-writing unit. ~~The unit will end before spring break.~~ Which plan is most culturally responsive?

Target word: culturally responsive design **Decides:** Students' experiences become assets in rigorous work.

A	Adjacent category	A surface event that does not change teaching.
B	Inverted operation	Lowers expectations instead of raising support.
C	Correct	Builds on students' cultures while keeping rigor.
D	Confusion set	A "colorblind" approach ignores students' assets.

7. Answer A Concept 5

A sixth-grade teacher ~~who uses a paper planner~~ writes the objective "Students will compare fractions using benchmarks like 1/2." Her planned quiz asks students to define "numerator" and "denominator." ~~The quiz has eight questions.~~ What is the problem?

Target word: alignment **Decides:** The quiz does not ask students to compare fractions.

A	Correct	Assessment must match the stated skill.
B	Adjacent category	More activities do not fix a mismatched assessment.
C	Inverted operation	The goal drives the assessment, not the reverse.
D	Dropped element	Same topic is not the same skill.

8. Answer D Concept 6

Seventh graders ~~in a room with a broken thermostat~~ grow restless and off task during a 50-minute lecture. ~~The teacher coaches track after school.~~ What is the best adjustment?

Target word: developmentally responsive planning **Decides:** Young adolescents need short segments, movement, and interaction.

A	Absolute language	Restlessness often reflects development, not defiance.
B	Adjacent category	Punishes a planning problem.
C	Inverted operation	Works against how young adolescents learn.
D	Correct	Matches the attention and social needs of young adolescents.

9. Answer A Concept 7

Students who once wrote paragraphs on paper now type the same paragraphs in a word processor, with no other change. ~~The school bought 150 new laptops this year.~~ Which SAMR level is this?

Target word: SAMR level **Decides:** Same task, new tool, no functional change.

A	Correct	The technology replaces paper without changing the task.
B	Inverted operation	Redefinition creates a task impossible without the technology.
C	Adjacent category	Modification redesigns the task.
D	Confusion set	Augmentation adds a functional improvement, such as built-in feedback.

10. Answer D Concept 7 • transfer

Students co-author a multimedia report with a class in another country and get live feedback from outside experts, which could not happen without the technology. Which SAMR level is this?

Target word: SAMR level **Decides:** The task is impossible without the technology.

A	Confusion set	Augmentation only improves an existing task.
B	Adjacent category	Modification redesigns a task that could still exist without the tool.
C	Inverted operation	Substitution changes nothing about the task.
D	Correct	The technology creates a new kind of task.

11. Answer C Concept 8

During a heated class debate ~~on the day of the school play~~, a student notices anger building and takes three slow breaths before responding calmly. ~~The debate topic was school uniforms.~~ Which SEL competency is the student showing most clearly?

Target word: SEL competency **Decides:** The student regulates the emotion, not just notices it.

A	Confusion set	Noticing the anger is self-awareness; acting to calm down goes further.
B	Adjacent category	Social awareness is understanding others' perspectives.
C	Correct	Regulating an emotion with a strategy is self-management.
D	Dropped element	Leaves out that the key action was regulating one's own emotion.

12. Answer B Concept 8 • transfer

A lesson asks students to retell a conflict from the other person's point of view and name how that person may have felt. Which SEL competency does it build?

Target word: SEL competency **Decides:** Taking another's perspective and empathizing.

A	Confusion set	Self-awareness focuses on one's own emotions.
B	Correct	Perspective-taking and empathy are social awareness.
C	Adjacent category	Decision-making weighs choices and consequences.
D	Inverted operation	Self-management turns inward to regulate oneself.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	11	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	10	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	0	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Formative vs. summative assessment	Formative assessment happens during learning and changes instruction; summative assessment measures learning at the end for a grade or report.	Deciding by format or by whether it is graded, instead of by purpose and timing.	An assessment described by when it happens and what the teacher does with it.
2	Proactive classroom management	Teach, model, and practice routines explicitly from the first days, and reinforce expected behavior.	Posting rules and reacting with consequences only after problems appear.	The first weeks of school or a new routine.
3	Cooperative learning structures	Real cooperative learning needs positive interdependence (each member is needed) and individual accountability (each member is assessed).	Assigning a group grade alone, which lets one student do all the work.	A group project where effort is uneven.
4	Culturally responsive teaching	Build on students' cultural knowledge and experiences as assets, with high expectations and rigorous content for all.	One-time celebrations, a "colorblind" approach, or lowering expectations.	A diverse class and "how should the teacher design the unit?"
5	Aligning objective, assessment, and activity	The assessment must ask students to do exactly what the objective states, and activities must prepare them for it.	Assessing the topic instead of the stated skill.	An objective next to an assessment plan.
6	Planning for the young adolescent brain	Young adolescents learn best with short focused segments, movement, social interaction, and meaningful choice, since self-regulation is still developing.	Treating restlessness as defiance, or lengthening lectures to "build stamina."	Restless or off-task young adolescents during long lecture.
7	SAMR levels of technology use	Substitution (same task, new tool), Augmentation (functional improvement), Modification (task significantly redesigned), Redefinition (task impossible without the technology).	Calling any use of a device a high level of integration.	A described technology use and "which level?"
8	The five SEL competencies	Self-awareness (recognize), self-management (regulate), social awareness (take perspective), relationship skills (communicate, cooperate), responsible decision-making (weigh choices).	Confusing recognizing an emotion (self-awareness) with regulating it (self-management).	A student behavior or lesson goal and "which competency?"

Course scope (public description): Middle Grades Methods equips future educators with the skills needed to effectively teach students in middle grades. The course covers characteristics of middle school learners, instructional strategies, assessment strategies, classroom management, creating a positive learning environment, and lesson planning tailored to young adolescents' developmental needs. Students will learn to engage diverse learners, integrate technology, and apply culturally responsive teaching practices. Throughout the course,

students will practice with pedagogical activities and demonstrate instructional skills, which will develop the ability to create dynamic and supportive middle-grade learning environments that promote both academic and social-emotional growth.